the plan you used last year is still the best choice. Reevaluate annually.

- **Know what's covered by your plan.** Some cover everything from prescription drugs to physical therapy sessions to chiropractic adjustments, while others cover a limited range of services. All are required to treat physical and mental health care the same. If you want to know the details, check your insurance company's website. For about six months on my first job, I didn't know that all I had to do was show my company insurance card at the drugstore to get my prescription medication for just $5. Not too swift. You'll also need to understand your plan's reimbursement policies. Many plans cover 70% to 80% of what they consider "usual, customary, and reasonable" out-of-network charges. If your doctor charges $100 for a checkup but your plan specifies that $60 is the reasonable and customary charge for a doctor in your area, the plan will reimburse you for $48 (80% of $60), leaving you to pay the remaining $ 52 yourself. If you know this in advance, you can explain the situation to your doctor and ask for a discount. Some doctors are surprisingly flexible.
- **See if you can get a higher deductible and pay a lower premium.** Some companies have a fixed deductible for all employees. A few base your deductible on your income, while others let you pick from two or more options. No matter how your employer sets your deductible, you should find out if you can raise it to keep your premium costs down. Again, you need to make sure you have enough savings to cover that deductible.
- **Ask about waiting periods or exclusions when you start a new job.** If you have any chronic medical problems, known in the insurance world as **preexisting conditions,** find out if your company insurance plan will cover you for these ailments immediately. Some plans will have a delay of up to 12 months, but most HMOs don't have any waiting period. And if you're transferring directly from a job where you had